3.6 Buoyancy

We already saw that a body experiences an upward force due to the fluid surrounding, when it is partially or fully immersed in to it. We also know that pressure is more at the bottom and less at the top of the liquid. This pressure difference causes a force on the object and pushes it upward. This force is called buoyant force and the phenomenon is called buoyancy (Fig.3.11).

Most buoyant objects are those with a relatively high volume and low density. If the object weighs less than the amount of water it has displaced (density is less), buoyant force will be more and it will float (such object is known as positively buoyant). But, if the object weighs more than the amount of water it has displaced (density is more), buoyant force is less and the object will sink (such object is known as negatively buoyant).

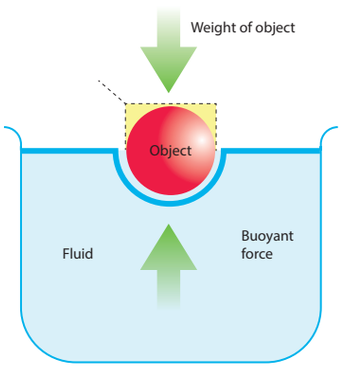


Figure 3.11 Buoyant force

DO YOU KNOW?

Salt water provides more buoyant force than fresh water, because, buoyant force depends as much on the density of fluids as on the volume displaced.

3.6.1 Cartesian diver

Cartesian diver is an experiment that demonstrates the principle of buoyancy. It is a pen cap with clay. The Cartesian diver contains just enough liquid that it barely floats in a bath of the liquid; its remaining volume is filled with air. When pressing the bath, the additional water enters the diver, thus increasing the average density of the diver, and thus it sinks.

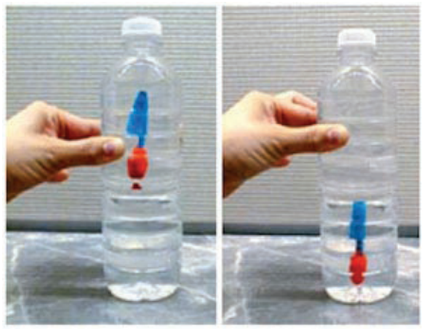


Figure 3.12 Cartesian diver

3.7 Archimedes' Principle

Archimedes principle is the consequence of Pascal's law. According to legend, Archimedes devised the principle of the 'hydrostatic balance' after he noticed his own apparent loss in weight while sitting in his bath. The story goes that he was so enthused with his discovery that he jumped out of his bath and ran through the town, shouting 'eureka'. Archimedes principle states that 'a body immersed in a fluid experiences a vertical upward buoyant force equal to the weight of the fluid it displaces'.

When a body is partially or completely immersed in a fluid at rest, it experiences an upthrust which is equal to the weight of the fluid displaced by it. Due to the upthrust acting on the body, it apparently loses a part of its weight and the apparent loss of weight is equal to the upthrust.

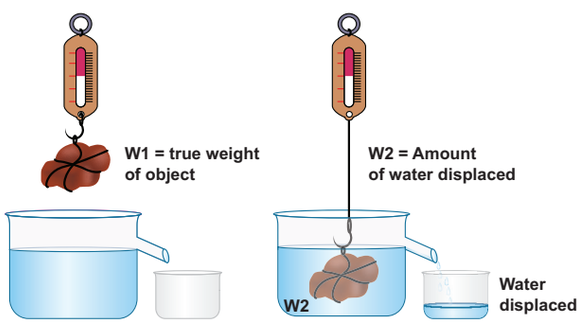


Figure 3.13 Upthrust is equal to the weight of the fluid displaced

Thus, for a body either partially or completely immersed in a fluid,

Upthrust = Weight of the fluid displaced
= Apparent loss of weight of the body.

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